



Greater Côa Valley

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Restoration Landscapes | Portugal

Restoring a 318,000-hectare wildlife corridor in northern Portugal to reconnect Mediterranean landscapes and revive rural opportunity.

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Project overview

The Greater Côa Valley in northern Portugal spans 318,000 hectares of rugged canyons, oak woodlands, montado and river systems. Located between the Malcata mountains and the Douro Valley, it forms a crucial wildlife corridor linking Mediterranean and Atlantic ecosystems.

For decades, rural depopulation, recurrent wildfires and fragmented land ownership weakened ecological processes. The absence of large herbivores simplified habitats. Human-wildlife conflict strained tolerance for predators such as Iberian wolf. Economic decline reinforced land abandonment and ecological degradation.

Led by Rewilding Europe and Rewilding Portugal, this project is rebuilding ecological connectivity across the valley, restoring natural grazing, strengthening coexistence systems and supporting a modern nature-based economy rooted in wildlife comeback.



Project location:

Greater Côa Valley, Beira Interior, Portugal

Lead partner

Rewilding Portugal

Grant duration

5 years

Grant size

US\$2,999,948

Landscape size:

318,000 ha

Key habitats:

Oak forests, rocky heathlands, river canyons, montado and riparian woodland

Focal species:

Iberian wolf, griffon vulture, Egyptian vulture, roe deer, red deer, sorraia horse, tauros cattle

Ecosystem services

Fire resilience, soil restoration, carbon storage, biodiversity recovery, nature-based tourism

Why this place matters



Frequent wildfires have had a significant effect on the ecosystems in this landscape.

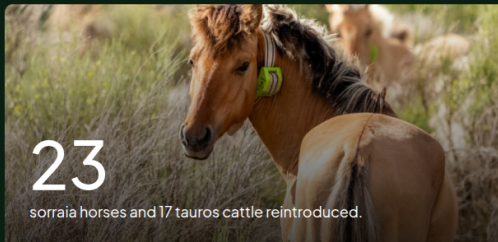
The Greater Côa Valley connects two Natura 2000 sites and includes the Côa Valley Archaeological Park, a UNESCO World Heritage Site. It sits at the southern edge of Portugal's Iberian wolf distribution and supports important populations of vultures and other raptors.

Frequent wildfires, driven by abandoned land and accumulated biomass, repeatedly interrupted ecological recovery. Fragmented private ownership made landscape-scale restoration difficult. Declining prey populations limited predator recovery, while rural communities struggled with economic decline.

Restoring connectivity and natural processes here strengthens fire resilience, supports wildlife comeback and creates new pathways for sustainable development.

Action on the ground

Across 318,000 hectares, restoration in the Greater Côa Valley is rebuilding ecological connectivity. Natural grazing, coexistence measures and community partnerships are reshaping the landscape.



23

sorraia horses and 17 tauros cattle reintroduced.

997

ha of land strategically purchased to strengthen corridor connectivity.

43

businesses joined the Wild Côa Network.



8,730

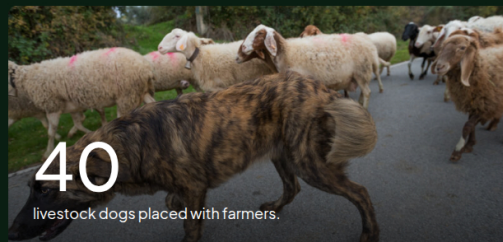
visitors attended the 2023 CÔA Corridor of Arts Festival.

73

farmers engaged in coexistence programmes.

656

ha under natural grazing regimes.



40

livestock dogs placed with farmers.

Monitoring highlights

The project team monitors a range of indicators covering topics ranging from ecological recovery to economic impacts and community engagement. This helps to inform adaptive management.

[Visit the Monitoring Hub](#)

 Scavengers	+
 Habitat Restoration	+
 Fire Risk	+
 Human-Wildlife Coexistence	+
 Wildlife-Friendly Products	+
 Nature-Based Economy	+

Restoration trial

Can semi-wild horses help reduce fire-risk in the Greater Côa Valley?



Project partners



Project achievements



Transforming human-wildlife coexistence

Coexistence with Iberian wolf is central to long-term restoration. The project works directly with livestock farmers to prevent predation and build trust.

Forty livestock guard dogs have been placed with farmers, alongside wolf-proof fencing and tailored support. More than 90% of participating farmers report high satisfaction with the measures provided.

An innovative partnership with Wilding Shoes has created a premium market for "wolf-friendly" wool. By paying higher prices and covering shearing costs, the scheme turns coexistence into tangible economic benefit.



Rewilding efforts in the Greater Côa Valley have transformed a once-fragmented landscape into a better-connected ecological corridor.

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Building a nature-based economy

Restoration is linked to economic renewal. The Wild Côa Network brings together 43 food producers, accommodation providers, guides and tourism operators aligned with rewilding principles.

More than 40 people from 14 businesses have received training to strengthen skills in nature-based tourism. The EXPERIENCE(COA) congress and the Corridor of Arts Festival have positioned the Greater Côa Valley as a reference point for rewilding-aligned development.

A Rewilding Centre in Vale de Madeira now serves as a gateway to the landscape, anchoring tourism, education and community engagement.

"This partnership is extremely important to us, as we are able to engage in open dialogue with a shared focus on the rewilding of the Greater Côa Valley, which is also a priority for the municipality of Pinhel. The work developed through this collaboration represents an essential lever for development in the region and for combating the demographic winter we are facing."

Daniela Capelo, Vice-President, municipality of Pinhel

"In 2019, the Greater Côa Valley was defined by rural abandonment, frequent fires, and the loss of key ecosystem functions. Fragmentation and recurring fire were the main challenges, but extensive areas freed from extractive use offered real opportunities for recovery. Our ambition was to scale up proven solutions across a wider landscape, restoring connectivity and building a functional coexistence corridor."

Pedro Prata, Team Leader, Rewilding Portugal

"I always use the fences because we don't know when the wolf will come. Before the fences there could be multiple attacks; now there are very few. If a wolf shows up the dogs will go after him, but the wolves usually work as a team, so there can be another one waiting. Inside the fences the wolf can't get in."

Joaquim Peralta, Sheep Farmer

What's next?

With momentum building, the project is preparing to scale restoration across the wider corridor. Long-term land

security, stronger prey populations and deeper community engagement will guide the next stage.

Wild Côa Network expanded and nature tourism scaled.

Rewilding Portugal Foundation established to secure long-term land protection.

5,000ha

brought under rewilding management by 2030.

Stronger prey base established to support Iberian wolf and lynx recovery.

Transboundary cooperation strengthened with Spain.

Scientific monitoring expanded to guide adaptive management.

Restoration Works

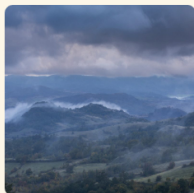
[Read the Greater Côa Valley report](#)

Restoration Works showcases the accomplishments of projects supported by the ELSP which have completed their funding period.

[Visit the Greater Côa Valley website](#)

[Visit website](#)

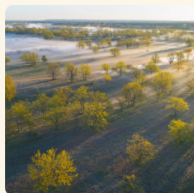
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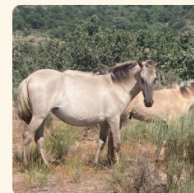
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